

InterQual® Specialty Rx Oncology Criteria

Review Process

Introduction

As part of the InterQual® Ambulatory Care Planning family of products, InterQual® Specialty Rx Oncology Criteria provide healthcare organizations with evidence-based clinical decision support for specialty pharmacy oncology medications. Healthcare providers and reviewers use the criteria to make effective utilization decisions at the point of care or during the preauthorization process.

Criteria are presented in an interactive question-and-answer (Q&A) format. As you conduct a review, your answers to questions about the patient's clinical presentation will lead you to the recommended medication.

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- ① The criteria reflect clinical interpretations and analyses and cannot alone either resolve medical ambiguities of particular situations or provide the sole basis for definitive decisions. The criteria are intended solely for use as screening guidelines with respect to the medical appropriateness of healthcare services and not for final clinical or payment determinations concerning the type or level of medical care provided, or proposed to be provided, to a patient.
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InterQual® content contains references to patient sex or gender. Depending on the context, these references may refer to either genotype or phenotype. At the individual patient level, a variety of factors, including but not limited to gender identity and gender affirmation via surgery or hormonal treatment, may affect the applicability of some InterQual Criteria. This occurs most often with genetic testing and some procedures that require the presence of specific anatomy. For the purpose of these criteria, references to Male and Female are based on sex assigned at birth, unless otherwise defined. InterQual users should carefully consider patient genotype and anatomy when appropriate.

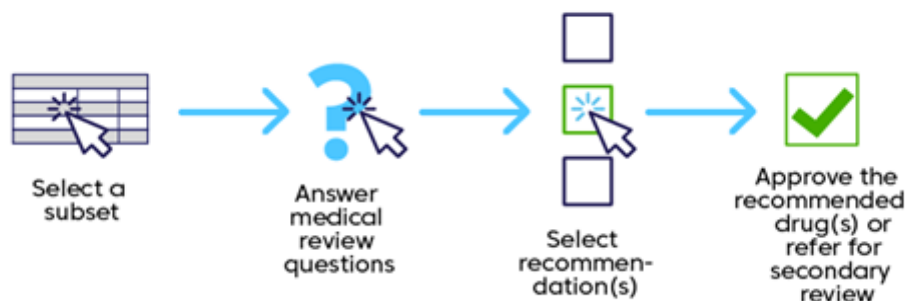
Informational notes

Notes provide information regarding best clinical practice, new clinical knowledge, explanations of criteria rationale, definitions of medical terminology, and literature references. The notes in the criteria are specific to each question and/or recommendation.

How to conduct a medical review

During a medical review, you use the criteria as a decision support tool to assess the medical appropriateness of a given specialty oncology medication. Although labeled as a “Medical Review” in the software, this type of review is also known as a primary review. This first-level review typically involves a non-physician reviewer who uses the criteria to determine if the request is appropriate or if the review requires secondary review.

Conduct a medical review as follows:



Step 1: Select a subset

Select a subset.

You can search for a subset using one or more of the following methods:

- **By category**—Categories identify the drugs that are available for medical review. Specialty Rx Oncology Criteria are organized by the following categories:
 - Oncologic
 - Supportive Care

Also, you may select All Categories to display all the oncology and supportive care drugs.

- **By keyword(s)**—Keywords are words found in the subset name or terms related to a specific drug.
- **By medical code(s)**—Medical codes include codes such as HCPCS codes.

A list of Specialty Rx Oncology drugs that are available for review will display, for example, Bevacizumab (Avastin) or Trastuzumab (Herceptin).

Step 2: Answer medical review questions

Answer the medical review questions based on the clinical scenario.

The medical review is a sophisticated, branching-logic algorithm based on medical evidence; a series of questions directs you to the most appropriate pathway based on the indications for the drug usage.

Your answers lead to the most appropriate recommendation(s).

Review Questions

When answering questions, keep the following guidelines in mind:

- For questions that enable you to select more than one answer choice, you must click Next to advance to the next question.
- In many questions, the last answer choice is "Other clinical information (add comment)." If the clinical scenario does not satisfy the other answer choices, select this answer. The following recommendation displays: "Current evidence does not support prescribing in this clinical scenario."
- Selecting "None of the above" displays the recommendation: "Current evidence does not support prescribing in this clinical scenario."
- Selecting "More choices" leads to another question with more clinical presentations.
- Selecting "None of the above, more choices" leads to additional questions. This option is used when there is a list of criteria (e.g., symptoms, findings, diagnoses, medical conditions) that must be reviewed prior to moving to the next question (e.g., risk factors for cancer, involuntary weight loss, dysphagia, odynophagia). If any of the listed criteria are present, it must be selected. If none of the listed criteria are present, select "None of the above, more choices" to advance to the next question.
- Selecting "None of the above, see recommendation" leads to a recommendation. This option is used when there is a list of criteria (e.g., symptoms, findings, diagnoses, medical conditions) that must be reviewed prior to moving to a recommendation (e.g., risk factors for cancer, involuntary weight loss, dysphagia, odynophagia). If any of the listed criteria are present, it must be selected. If none of the listed criteria are present, select "None of the above, see recommendation" to advance directly to a recommendation.

Reviewer comments can be added at any time during the review.

Step 3: Select recommendation

Review and select a recommendation to authorize the appropriate drug. Based on your organizational policies, you can also select the appropriate ICD-10CM, CPT®, and/or HCPCS codes.

Recommendations

The recommendation that displays after you answer the questions in a pathway are based on the best available medical evidence and current practice. Once the medical review is completed, depending on the pathway taken, you will be led to any of the following recommendations:

- One drug is recommended.
- No drug is recommended: "Current evidence does not support prescribing in this clinical scenario."
- A drug is recommended and flagged as "This recommendation is designated as Limited Evidence in this clinical scenario. Criteria cannot be met." A note will display "Recommendations are designated as "Limited Evidence" based on one or more of the following:
 - Research to date has not demonstrated this intervention's equivalence or superiority to the current standard of care.
 - The balance of benefits and harms does not clearly favor this intervention.
 - The clinical utility of this intervention has not been clearly established.
 - The evidence is mixed, unclear, or of low quality.
 - This intervention is not standard of care.
 - New technology is still being investigated.
- The NCCN Compendium Rating accompanies all Off-label recommendations. Clicking the NCCN Compendium Rating® icon displays the www.nccn.org website. Moving the pointer over the rating designation (e.g., 1, 2A, 2B, 3) defines the rating based on evidence and consensus. The NCCN Compendium Rating® icon displays as follows:

NCCN Compendium® Rating 2A

- Definitions for NCCN Categories

The specific definitions of the NCCN categories for recommendations are included below:

- Category 1: Based upon high-level evidence, there is uniform NCCN consensus that the intervention is appropriate
- Category 2A: Based upon lower-level evidence, there is uniform NCCN consensus that the intervention is appropriate
- Category 2B: Based upon lower-level evidence, there is NCCN consensus that the intervention is appropriate
- Category 3: Based upon any level of evidence, there is major NCCN disagreement that the intervention is appropriate

Next action(s)

Your next action(s) depends on the medical review results as shown in the following table:

Medical review results	Select recommendation(s)	Action(s)
According to current evidence, one recommendation is appropriate in this clinical scenario. (View notes, if any, for details.)	Recommended: - Recommended Off-label Recommended (an NCCN rating accompanies this recommendation)	Approve the recommended drug based on organizational policies pertaining to the NCCN ratings.
According to current evidence, one recommendation is based on limited evidence (LE). If LE recommendations are selected, medical review is suggested based on payer policy. (View notes for details.) The criteria enable reviewers to proactively gather and document patient-specific clinical information for medical review.	Limited Evidence 	Refer for secondary review as dictated by your organizational policies
Current evidence does not support prescribing in this clinical scenario	No recommendations displayed	Obtain additional information from the requesting physician if needed. - If the additional information satisfies the medical review, the request may be approved for the recommended drug - If the additional information does not satisfy the medical review, or if no further information is available, refer for secondary review as dictated by your organizational policies
Cancel current review		Cancel the review
No recommendations were made based on the answers to the Medical Review questions. Please answer all questions.	Medical review incomplete	Answer all questions

Step 4: Approve the recommended drug or refer for secondary review

Outcome referral reasons

Referral reasons identify why the proposed request does or does not meet medical necessity or medical appropriateness. Examples include criteria issues, such as no criteria to cover indication/diagnosis/procedure, and provider issues, such as test results incomplete. Referral reasons vary from product to product and display based on the selected outcome.

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- ① **SOFTWARE NOTE:** In InterQual® Cloud Solutions, an organization can add as many outcomes and reasons as they need to meet their needs. In Review Manager, an organization can add their own specific referral reasons and create unique outcome groups to delete or hide existing referral reasons.
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Secondary Review

Secondary review determines the appropriateness of a request (e.g., imaging or diagnostic study, procedure, equipment) when it is not supported by criteria on primary review. Organizational policy should dictate the extent to which secondary review is performed to render a review outcome.

When is secondary review appropriate?

The following scenarios may indicate that a secondary review is appropriate:

- **Criteria subset not listed.** Only the more common interventions or equipment are included in criteria. InterQual content does not currently cover this request. This does not mean that the request is inappropriate, but that it is less common or emerging and requires secondary review.
- **Indications not listed.** An indication for the request is not listed.
- **Criteria not available for the age group.** The criteria do not cover the age group requested.
- **Criteria not met.** When the answers to the questions lead to a recommendation "Current evidence does not support x in this clinical scenario."
- **Recommendation with Secondary review required and Limited Evidence, or Secondary review required.** These criteria have been developed to provide reviewers with a basis for proactively gathering and documenting patient-specific clinical information that will facilitate secondary review.
- **Patient choice and preference.** The criteria delineate reasonable courses for most patients. Some patients refuse certain prerequisite therapies or testing; these cases require secondary review.

Who is responsible for completing a secondary review?

A secondary review may be completed by a supervisor, medical practitioner, subject matter-expert or designated clinician. A medical practitioner is **not** required to perform a secondary review; however, some regulatory requirements specify that only a physician can issue a final non-determination (denial) decision.

Secondary Review steps

1. The secondary reviewer determines medical necessity based on review of the medical record; discussions with members of the interdisciplinary team (e.g., nursing staff, the discharge planner, therapists, and the attending medical practitioner); and clinical knowledge and judgement.

① The secondary reviewer is not required to but may choose to apply InterQual Criteria when completing a secondary review. Best practice would include reviewing the results of the primary review to ensure internal agreement in criteria application.

To determine medical necessity, it may be appropriate for the secondary reviewer to consider other factors in the determination, such as:

- Age
- Co-morbid conditions (e.g., medical, substance use, and psychiatric disorders)
- Treatment response and patient engagement
- History of non-compliance and health outcomes
- Availability (e.g., a drug not available in the formulary or an imaging test/procedure not available on-site)
- Other organization- or patient-specific factors

① **Tip:** A primary reviewer can assist the secondary review process by including the outcome of the InterQual review, as well as documentation that could support these additional factors.

2. Determine the review outcome:
 - If the secondary reviewer agrees with the request, approve.
 - If the secondary reviewer does not agree with the request, discuss the optimal alternate management for this patient with the requesting provider.
 - If the requesting provider does not agree with the secondary reviewer's determination, a specialist may become involved in the review process.
3. Document the review outcome.

Reference materials

Reference materials are provided with the criteria and should be used to assist in the correct interpretation of the criteria. Reference materials include:

- **Abbreviations and Symbols List**—Defines acronyms, abbreviations, and symbols used in the criteria.
- **Bibliography**—Provides references cited in the clinical content.
- **Clinical Revisions**—Provide details of changes to InterQual Clinical Criteria.
- **Drug List**—Categorizes drug names and classes mentioned within the criteria.

Additional Resources

InterQual® Resource Center

The [InterQual Resource Center](#) is a central location for the most up-to-date InterQual clinical documentation and resources.

The Resource Center provides access to:

- **What's New**—Includes release highlights for each of the InterQual® Criteria modules included in a content release.
- **Clinical Revisions**—Includes the clinical revisions for the current InterQual Criteria year and two years prior.
- **Clinical Resources**—Includes information such as the Knowledge Articles, Known Issues List, the InterQual® Behavioral Health Criteria Crosswalk to CMS, and more.
- **Webinars**—Includes access to the on-demand *Increase Your IQ* educational webinars.
- **Additional Resources**—Includes access to resources such as Customer Connection, the InterQual® Learning Source, and Download Connect.

Customer Connection

[Customer Connection](#) is a web portal that provides the ability to:

- Submit, update, and view support case details and status
- Link to the InterQual Resource Center where you can find the Knowledge Articles and other clinical resources

To obtain a user ID and password, from the Customer Connection Welcome page, click the *Register Now* link.